

Yuyang Yao

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Faculty of Linguistics, Philology and Phonetics
University of Oxford
Oxford, United Kingdom

Research Interests

Cognitive Science of Language; Computational Modelling of Language Processing; Human-Large Language Models Comparison; Mechanistic Interpretability of Language Models

Education & Academic Training

- 2025 – 2027 **MPhil in Linguistics, Philology and Phonetics**
University of Oxford, Oxford, United Kingdom
Provisional thesis: Phonological Prediction in Mandarin Spoken Comprehension
Supervisor: Adam Chong
- 2021 – 2025 **B.A. in German**, GPA: 92/100
Beijing Foreign Studies University, Beijing, China
Thesis: The Representations and Alternations of German Dorsal Obstruents
Advisor: Jing Li
- 2023 – 2024 **Academic Exchange Programme in German Philology**
Georg August University of Göttingen, Göttingen, Germany
- Aug – Sep 2026 **Visiting Research Scholar**
University of Connecticut, Storrs, United States
Dept. of Psychological Science
PI: James Magnuson

Publications

Chen, T., **Yao, Y.**, & Tang, L. (2026). Do LLMs Adapt Politeness Like Humans? *Proceedings of the 2026 Conference on Empirical Methods in Natural Language Processing (EMNLP 2026)*.

In Preparation

* denotes equal contribution

Yao, Y., Peng, L., & Magnuson, J. Emergence of Syntactic Sensitivity in a Developmental Speech Recognition Model.

Chen, T.* & **Yao, Y.*** Investigating Speech Representations in Audio Language Models Using Sine-Wave Speech.

Awards

National Scholarship (Ministry of Education, China)	2022
Academic Scholarship (Beijing Foreign Studies University)	2023
Scholarship for Overseas Exchange (Beijing Foreign Studies University)	2023

Language & Technical Skills

Languages: Mandarin (native), English (fluent), German (fluent), Tok Pisin (elementary)
Programming: Python, R
Machine Learning: PyTorch, Hugging Face transformers, Neural network modelling (CNNs, RNNs/LSTMs, Transformers, State Space Models)
Computing: Linux, HPC clusters, SLURM
Other: L^AT_EX, Praat